

(Almost) No theory, Just a Task

A Regime Theory of Joy

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The Minimal Z-reduction Task: Decrease Evaluation, Get Access to Joy

Q: Count as "joy": Lasting increased olfaction, increased visual vividness, chest pleasure reacting, and sudden stronger reaction to music. Out-of-task generalization after 48h. The state switches on all at once, like a light being turned on.



Without joy / With joy: Increased visual vividness

Strong, stable, true joy exists, but is blocked by evaluation. Attempts at self pursuit, or evaluating, prevent entry. However, if entry happens, the state becomes solid and easy to re-enter the following months.

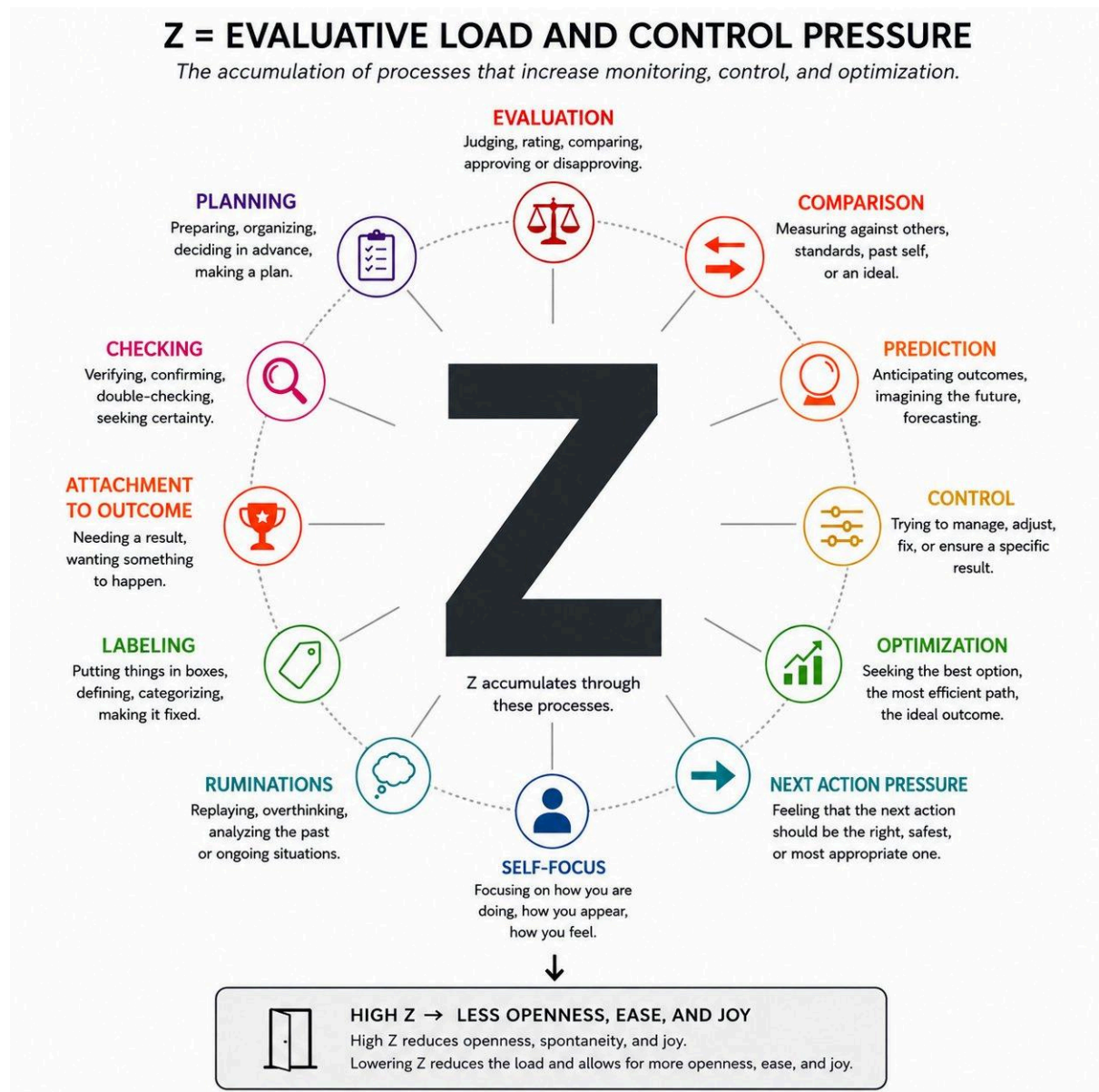
The Low Z Mindset

If a moment is going well, why change it? Why search for the best song, the best place, the best setting? Why seeking improvement? This mindset maintains a low pressure of action, but is rare after ~15 years old.

Z, the Weight of Destiny

Z is the weight of destiny: the sense that a moment carries evaluation or a next action. It can also be seen as felt seriousness, or as the quest-like mindset. Self-pursuit is one of its components. Evaluation, labelling, planning the next action, trying to focus to understand something, also raises Z. Almost everything raises Z (See figure), except the low Z mindset above. Hence why no one in the world report strong daily joy after

childhood. Even children don't report it, yet actually got it, and we will see why later in the text.



While you are reading this text, seriousness increases, and so does Z. Your chance to feel joy therefore is a little bit decreasing as you read this text right now. ;)

When Z falls, more pleasant brain regimes become easier to enter, including the most sought-after: joy.

In early childhood, Z is very low, and joy is actually the baseline (but still collapses in classroom). To the point children barely notice it, and therefore never report it. In adults, strong joy does not happen anymore: daily destiny weight is extremely high.

At school, at least, there were genuine breaks everywhere: periods in which nothing further *could even be done*.

In contrast, in adulthood , there is a sense that every major choice is endlessly revisable, as though it could be changed every 10 minutes.

Many behaviours increase Z. But the relation is reciprocal: once Z is elevated, it also increases the pull toward them. **Hence, many people don't even try the Z-reduction task, which is annoying to me, but was expected by the model.**

Z = Weight of Destiny

The felt load of evaluation, consequence, and next-action pressure.

Daily Life Example: Choosing a Sidewalk

When we have to choose a sidewalk, we often select one side and treat it as the one that will somehow “carry us,” while the other is treated as the worse option. This gives one side a weight of destiny, as a small quest. Z rises.



Instead, one can briefly equalize: “I have to choose a side, but the two sides remain equal.” (Note: You don’t say anything in you head, you just equalize). Here, you still choose one, but the weight of destiny attached to that choice stays low: both sides remain briefly mentally equal in importance. Z is reduced.

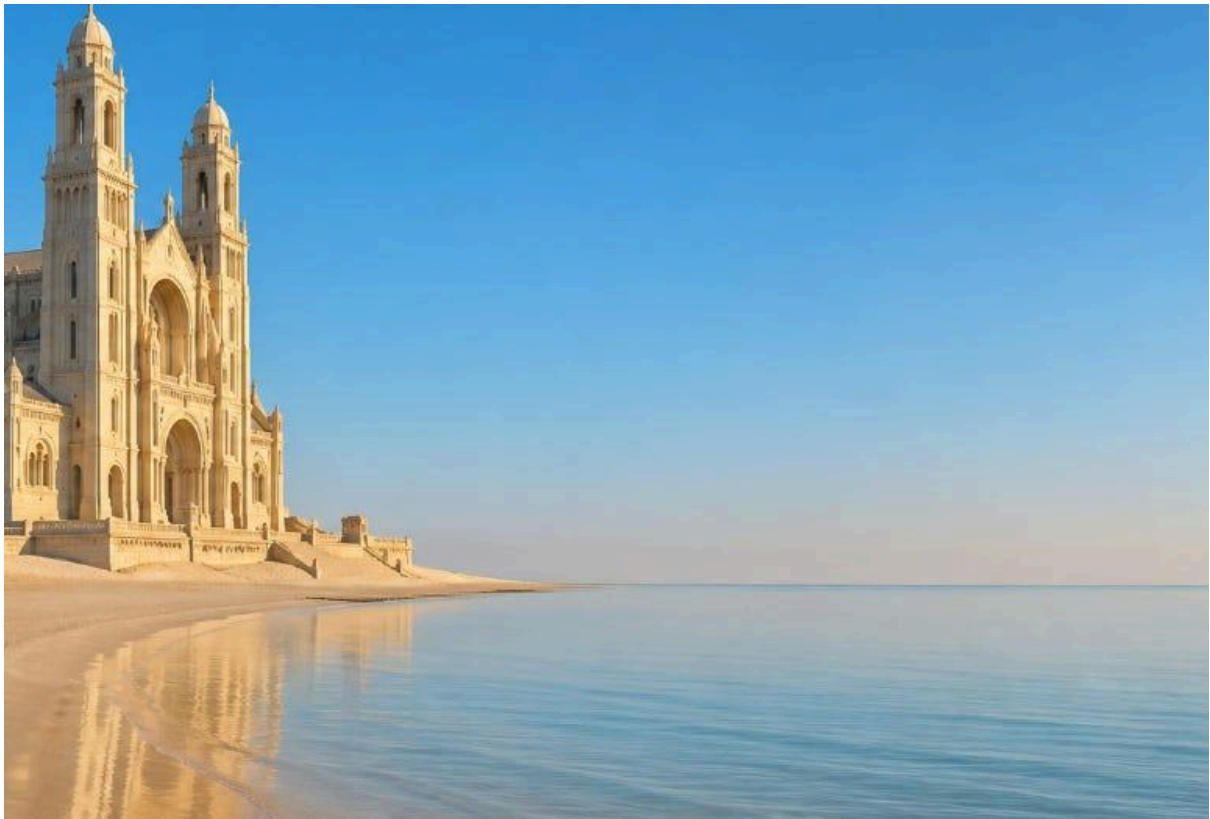
However, if you do this at every corner, it becomes “the technique for reducing Z.” Likewise, if you evaluate the task, “Did I successfully avoid comparing?”, the exercise itself then acquires a weight of destiny, and Z increases.

If you do the any Z reduction exercise while focusing on the result, Z increases.

In a typical week, Z falls the saturday, but increases again the sunday or monday, when planification re-enter the cognition. This is how Z feels. Z is therefore something relatively easy to notice, but noticing it increases it a bit.

The aim is not to eliminate instrumental functioning, but to restore flexible access to a non-instrumental regime.

Some visuals decrease Z, such as faces images, music videos and horizons, because they don't ask for an action. As faces images and horizons are also affectively charged, one can feel a response, specially if combined with a music track.

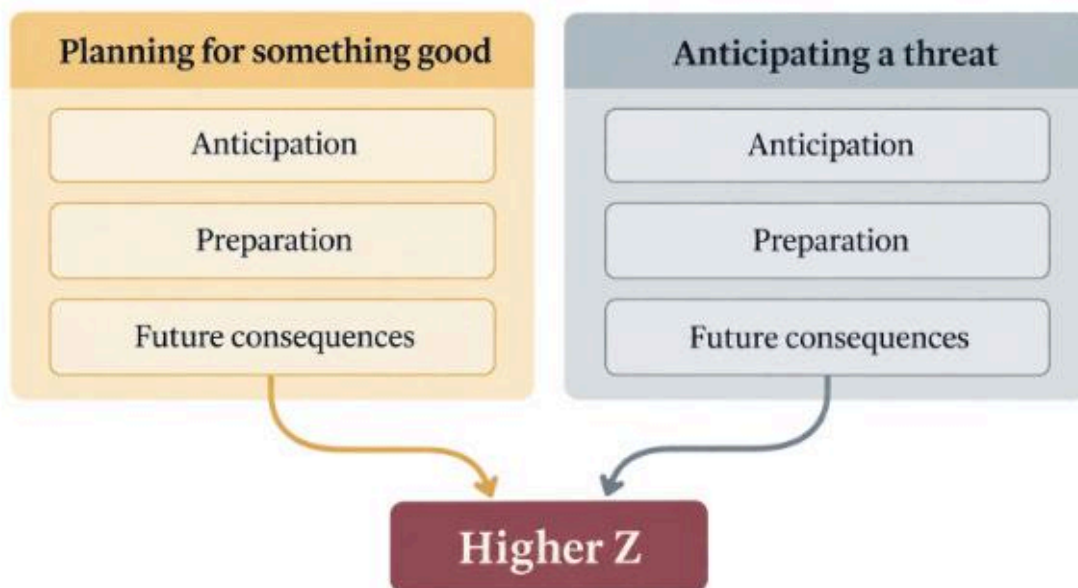


When combined with music and low evaluation, horizon images can trigger an affective response.

Many popular music are better-suited for lowering Z than others, because they seem to not ask for an action. Popular exemples: Modjo lady, Fallin Alicia Keys, Bigbang- Bad boy, Boney M Daddy Cool.

Positive and negative anticipation

Different feeling, similar future-oriented load



Lowering Z therefore, is about flattening both good evaluation and bad evaluation. Both increases seriousness, quest like feelings, and therefore raise Z. So, congratulating oneself, raises Z. Certainly less than many other behaviors, but I point out again that anything departing from “There is nothing to optimize”, increases Z, including good things. Searching for salience, including good spots in nature, the next new music, the best product offer, raise Z.

Where People Struggle the Most: Making it Simple

Because the problem with someone Z high, therefore almost everyone or even everyone, is that if you ask them this simple action:

Make a micro mouvement (eg. move your right hand), and that's all. Don't verify for any result, don't evaluate, just forget and continue.

This simple thing is difficult. This is the result of decades of evaluative environnement. The Z high mind automatically recruits many questions, evaluation, anticipation, recall, before, or after any simple move, all the time.

From there, I'll show you some Z high situations, and how to curb them, in theory.

The Present Moment

The idea that the present moment must be fully attended to, is embedded in our culture. But treating the present as important increases Z.

One Among Many exercise offers a different stance: instead of treating the current moment as the only that counts, it is briefly lived as one insignificant moment among many. It can be a tiny action.

You can briefly frame a mouse click as one click among others. A selected book is only one among others. A webpage is only one among others. A street is only one among others.

Objects

Seeing objects through their functions increases Z. You look at your keys, you activate automatically its function. When we enter a room, we notice equipment, and immediately assign it a use. The felt weight of destiny of the scene rises, and so does Z.





If you feel like this when entering a room, Z is very high.

Pause Before Utility:

After picking up an object, let it remain in your hand briefly before using it.

Several Objects Together:

Briefly notice several objects together before one becomes the focus. “The” item is less charged in destiny if it is seen as “one among many” then focused on.

Colors

Colors are integrated into object recognition and functional interpretation. Yellow street signs, even nature colors indicate functions: trees create shadows, sunlight indicates approximately the hour, etc.

Let the Colors Stand Out:

Briefly let the colors in the scene stand out without becoming signals for action.

Importance

When we see items, we label them correctly all the time. Every item is precisely categorized: If asked, anyone can make a precise hierarchy of all items they know by value or price, without making any error.

Disrupting this hierarchy is a good way to decrease Z, as long as you don’t justify the new hierarchy.

Label an ordinary item as “important”, or “precious”. If you don’t add anticipation, evaluation, or verification, it is one of the cleanest exercise, because it breaks the logic of Z at its core: what is important, what to do next with it.

Preferences

Having a preferred place, or preferred destination can lead to planning around it, and therefore high Z. It is the “Do I go [insert place] today?”, or the “I wish I was at this place, because it is the best”.

Thinking, “*It will be great there,*” increases Z by increasing anticipation, comparison, and the search for evidence as an additional mini-task.

Cinema, Series, YouTube and games.

All constantly call for what comes next: unanswered questions and, of course, narrative continuation.

Much of this content is designed for a high-Z audience. It offers rewards suited to an evaluative regime.

An other exception is a child consuming those medias, because its behavior will still remains low Z without effort, wich is compatible with joy. Those medias, for a children, are very intensive in joy. But **not** for an adult.

You can, if you are adult and seeking joy, still use those medias, but only for 1-5 minutes in total. You can:

One Scene is Enough:

Let one scene exist on its own without anticipating the next one.

Meaning Left Open:

Briefly let something be understood only partway, good for both videos and books,

Neutral Liking:

Briefly watch a character without deciding whether you like or dislike them.

On meta-data:

Another Artist:

For one second, let a track seem as though it belonged to a different artist.

Playlist Without a Center:

Look at the entire folder as though no track in it is the center.

Books

Starting a book and searching for meaning is a quest-like behavior. Instead:

Paragraph Fragments:

Open a book at any page, and read some lines in an unordered fashion. If you happen to not understand the story, good.

Imagination

At times, you can refrain from extending your imagination by leaving unimagined what might be happening behind an obstacle. For example, for a second, don't imagine what is behind your computer screen right now. Probably there is a wall, and you will notice that your mind was monitoring it.

No Event:

In your head, Imagine a place where nothing happens; then let it fade.

Fading Image Once:

Imagine a simple item, notice when it fades. Don't add another image.

Sacralization

Sacralization is when something stands out as special, important, or meaningful, Z rises. Example: A book is seen as precious, because it is the "knowledge of humanity".

One possible exercise is to mentally equalize a sacred object with what *surrounds it*. The same can apply to software options. Some icons, options are "sacred", for example shutting down button, the window cross, the timebar.

Another trick to reduce the "sacred" quality of perception is:

What Appears, Appears:

Look at or open something. Briefly, there is nothing you need to feel. Example:

A child opens a drawer “just to see,” and what appears appears. Then the child moves on to another activity. An adult would open it for a reason and immediately begin drawing conclusions: What are these objects? Why are they here? What are they for?



Open something → see, that's it. No evaluation is taking place. Then continue.

Don't Verify

The clearest example occurs when we lock the front door. We often go back to make sure that it is “properly locked.”..

Don't Verify: At times, move an object without verifying, provided that it does not become a method, which would add verification to the non-verification itself and becomes a mini-quest again.

Alternative:

The Action Is Enough:

Briefly let one small action be “enough”. Then continue.

Agency

See your hands movements as “it happened” instead of being the author. It is useful because it reduces the quest-like feature of movement itself.

Category Softening

On the computer, briefly let a button seem a little less clearly to be “a button.”

Let an icon seem not quite completely like an icon. Targets the rigidity of categories, and so their quest-like, serious component.

Open questions

In the the news, a process maintains destiny-like thinking: questions left open. News headlines often avoid answering the subject directly.

For example: “LIVE. White House meeting: the president will speak after meeting with party leaders.” Reading this immediately raises quest-like questions such as “Why?”, “When?”, and “With whom?”, because the relevant information has been withheld from the headline.

Title Without a Question:

Sometimes, read a news title but don’t treat it as a question that needs an answer.

Question Without Answer:

Think of a simple question. Do not search for an answer. Let the question fade.

Next Action

One important principle of quest-like thinking: what to do next?

Before the Next Action:

Briefly let the next action remain undecided. Then continue normally.

Failed Quest Object:

Look at an object as if it were a quest object in a game. Then abandon the quest immediately.

Useless Clue:

An object becomes a clue. But the investigation never begins.

Social Life

Apart from local playground games, social life tends to involve a considerable amount of destiny-like thinking. Consider this: waiting for someone, having an appointment, searching for arguments, talking about oneself, or imagining other people’s reactions.

Complete enough:

In a light conversation context, you can say something once “as if it is complete enough.”

Recognition or Approval:

Alone, generate a feeling of recognition or approval. Normally, perceiving a character rapidly recruits evaluation, interpretation, or preparation for a social response - quest-like behaviors -. This exercise briefly generates a simple feeling of recognition, allowing it to exist without needing to act on it.

Hello for Nothing:

Say “hello” without checking how it was received.

Don't justify yourself too much. If late, just say "sorry, I am late" and that's it.

Walking outside

Normally, walking is directed toward a goal: reaching a destination, exercising, or exploring. Occasionally, take one step that is slightly too long or too short, or speed up/slow down for no reason, then return to your normal pace, so that the whole walk is not entirely directed toward a purpose.

Arrival Is Not Urgent:

For a brief moment, the exact moment of arrival becomes less important.

Valuing Pleasure

Two things matter here: avoid assigning special value to the state, and sometimes even interrupt it deliberately, for example by stopping a song just as you begin to enjoy it.

Thoughts such as "This has to continue" increase perceived value and evaluation, causing the peak to collapse rather than sustaining it.

Just an Mp4:

Briefly see a video you like as simply an MP4 file.

Ordinary detail:

Briefly notice one visual detail that is irrelevant to what you are doing.

Those 2 exercises will, at first, collapse any pleasure, which is something that must be tolerated. Trying to protect the state, is a quest-like behavior, and so collapses it.

As a Conclusion: Within a Video Game (2-5 minutes)

Choose a video game, decrease its quest-like feeling:

- ignore score, ignore game instructions
- don't try to win
- do suspension moves, for example changing direction for no reason, firing one time beside an enemy,
- add any brief exercise you want, *keep them spaced* 1 per 30sec/1min and the session short

Florian Morin proposes that joy is gated by evaluative monitoring: joy does not simply fade, it becomes inaccessible when monitoring and optimization remain active.

References

Morin, F. (2026). A Regime Theory of Joy: The Ease Regime as a Permissive Control Configuration. SSRN. <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6711318>

Morin, Florian, Evaluative Monitoring and Access to Intense Positive Affect: The Minimal Z-Reduction Task Framework (June 06, 2026). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=6888300> or <https://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.6888300>